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Symbolic Exchange: Taking Theory Seriously. An Interview with Jean Baudrillard

Roy Boyne and Scott Lash

It was agreed beforehand that the interview would bear on questions raised in *Symbolic Exchange and Death*, but that Baudrillard would not confine himself to explicating that book and would develop the issues raised there as he saw them now.

SL: What struck me when I read Mike Gane's Introduction to the English translation of *Symbolic Exchange and Death* was something you said in an interview of 1991 about this being a more serious, conceptual, philosophical book than many of the others you have written. You were a little disappointed at its being picked up by the fine arts milieu and not much discussed from the analytical, conceptual point of view.

JB: That's right. It didn't produce much of an echo or resonance. But, where the fine arts people are concerned, they have mainly latched on to the simulation, simulacra side of my work, rather than *Symbolic Exchange*. They took their lead much more from the simulacra-simulations-seduction line of thinking.

It's true that the book was well received, but not discussed. That's part of a more general problem. I'm not received as a philosopher's philosopher. I'm not institutionally legitimated, so to speak, by the philosophers, and not just by the academic, professional philosophers, but also by the rather more subtle philosophers, if I may put it that way – those people I consider to be the true philosophers. Even among them, the book wasn't discussed. I regretted that a little, but in the end I took the view that that was the rule of the game or, rather, the law of that milieu.

In a way, the barrier erected against me in that world has grown bigger. Some of my other books on what might be termed more

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frivolous subjects (not for me, but that's how they see it) have been taken as a pretext not to confront the philosophical problematic I've been concerned with – the question of the object, of reversibility, etc.

SL: This book is published in a serious collection read by theoretical sociologists, cultural theorists and philosophers . . .

JB: That may change the way things work out.

SL: Our PhD students read Baudrillard, Bataille, Levinas, Heidegger . . . all together.

JB: Yes, I'm a great admirer of the way these things are done in other countries. In France, barriers are put up, people have their territories. Elsewhere – in Australia, Brazil, Britain, the USA – things are quite different. People read everything at the same time, which is good in a way. At least there are cross-fertilizations which don't happen in France on account of a sort of marginalization mechanism there which is also a form of sclerosis of the intellectual milieu. But that's how it is. Obviously, I haven't been accepted by the sociologists. But I haven't been adopted by the philosophers either. [Laughter.] I've been rejected by both the feminists and the political activists, so in the end, there isn't much left. A situation of total freedom.

RB: The question which interests me is that of subjectivity. How do things stand now with subjectivity? What is the relationship between subjectivity and postmodernity, subjectivity and symbolic exchange? Kantian morality, for example, is built on the terrain of decision, judgement . . .

JB: My reply here perhaps justifies the barrier philosophers have put up against me to some extent, in that my thinking isn't grounded in a study of the history of ideas, of Kant, etc. I decided rather on a kind of 'take-off' without references, creating an almost artificial situation, a kind of radical phenomenology . . .

The problem which obsessed me – I had a personal obsession from the outset – was that of the object, the material object, the object of consumption and so on, and that subsequently became a kind of problematic of the object in a much more metaphysical

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sense, or even a sense which goes beyond that. Though this doesn't apply to my first books, from *Symbolic Exchange* onwards, there was an attempt to look beyond the strategies of the subject, beyond subjectivity, beyond the subject of knowledge, of history, of power, etc., and to go and take a look at the object side – which in sociological terms also meant looking at the masses, etc. Or in the sciences, to look at the object, not the subject of science. So, the kind of fascination or seduction came from the object.

This wasn't so much a philosophical argument. There was, rather, a seduction, a temptation to find a kind of dual relation with the object which wouldn't be a subject–object or dialectical relation, to see if there wasn't perhaps on the object side (though you can't go over totally to the object side, of course, since that inevitably involves a paradox) even an impasse, to see whether there wasn't another logic developing, or another paralogic, another strategy, whether from the political, sociological and also philosophical point of view – or even from a scientific one. Obviously, I'm not an expert in the sciences, but I know that the problem of the object of the sciences is a crucial one today. So, in my first books, and up to *Symbolic Exchange*, while I drew on the official disciplines – semiology, psychoanalysis, Marxism – I always tried to come at those disciplines from the angle of their object, to take the side of the object against the discipline that claimed to be master of it. That was more or less what I was doing there.

Now, admittedly, this isn't a particularly philosophical approach. It's really more pataphysical, though let's not get too bogged down in that term here. But there was also a kind of situationism in this – taking the world as it is, taking it as a kind of radical self-evidence. And rediscovering radicality not in radical subjectivity, but in radical objectivity. Though not in an objectivity of a rationalist type, obviously. But there was a kind of *parti pris*, a kind of gamble or challenge there; so this wasn't a serene, objective philosophical choice, but, quite the contrary, a kind of *parti pris* to choose the object. And also a decision to try to seduce the object. The problem was no longer one of producing the object, producing the methods for investigating the object, but seducing the object [laughter] – being seduced by it and seducing it. This is a quite other type of relation.

RB: Is there any connection with concepts like Melanie Klein's part object?

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JB: There are aspects of that. Speaking of the object is too general. It can take on all kinds of forms: fractal, partial, and can even be perfectly enigmatic, the object having the form of a puzzle, a paradox — something unintelligible in some way. And the objective of theory here — let's call it theory, because it isn't philosophy we're talking about — is, ultimately, to make the world more unintelligible. Not to explain the world and cast light on it. We aren't in the Enlightenment any more. The object of theory can possibly be conceived in terms of symbolic exchange, where the law is that something is given to you and you have to give it back and, if possible, give back *more* — the *surplus-value* of symbolic exchange. The position is, then, that the world is given to us, and given to us as unintelligible: we have to render it even more unintelligible. We have to render it, to give it back [*le rendre*]; we don't necessarily have to master it, calculate it, compute it, but we have to give it back more enigmatic than it is. This is the problem as I see it now. The world is, in a way, too intelligible, too transparent. Though perhaps not truly so, at bottom. But we live in a system of total — and even totalitarian — explanation, exploration and investigation and the real task of theory is to complicate the object.

RB: We play, but we do not understand that we are playing.

JB: At bottom, yes, what we are involved in is a game — with rules, not in mastery, laws, protocols of knowledge, etc. But I don't mean to claim that this is a particularly special or original position. I believe a great number of philosophers do something other than just philosophize. Everyone finds themselves confronted sooner or later with this kind of enigma of the object. Obviously, a great part of thought is trapped in the identification of the subject or the problematic of subjectivity. Now, this can be extremely complex and rich: one can go very deeply into subjectivity and see it ramify in all directions. And it gives us psychology and the like. It's very interesting. But perhaps something else is in play.

SL: A question about 'production'. You speak in *Symbolic Exchange* of accumulation, production and stockpiling, which naturally made me think of the Heideggerian '*Bestand*' in 'The Question Concerning Technology'. And there, for Heidegger, 'production' (*Herstellung*) is part of a series, with representation (*Vorstellung*), subsumed under the notion of *Gestell* . . .

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JB: '*Stell*' again, yes . . .

SL: I'd like to know what you mean by production, not just within that Heideggerian framework, but whether stockpile, accumulation, irreversibility and the idea of 'terms'. . . . In *Symbolic Exchange* there are no terms in the same sense . . .

JB: Ah, yes, in *Symbolic Exchange*, there are no 'terms'. That's right. There are no poles or polarization of that kind. There's a kind of cycle, but can we picture that as involving 'terms'? It is a form, at least.

SL: And the production of an object? . . .

JB: This is difficult because at the point when I wrote *Symbolic Exchange* the term 'production' was so much in the air. It was such an accepted historical, materialist, Marxist term that there was, in the end, no need to define it. Material production, yes, the production of goods . . . but I analysed this a little more as the production of signs . . .

SL: . . . of desire?

JB: Yes. And production of differences, in fact. Perhaps the real system of mastery of the world is the production of differences, i.e. bringing terms into being. There is a kind of confusion or indeterminacy of things; to bring forth a distinction or polarization of terms is a kind of dialectic which allows you to master the game and to neutralize it at the same time, to harness difference. Or, alternatively, production can be the act of harnessing desire in objects. The object is also a mode of crystallization. The object is a difference, as it exists at a particular moment – i.e. distinctive, isolated. It is, manifestly, differential. So it enters into a system of a structure of differences. So much for production.

To production I had opposed seduction, seduction being precisely what abolishes this polarization. Seduction can't be said to be the same thing as symbolic exchange, but there is a paradigm which is more or less the same from the start, whether we're talking about seduction, symbolic exchange, the feminine, death . . .

SL: expenditure . . .

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But this concept of seduction has been so badly misunderstood that I've more or less given it up. And the same goes for the symbolic. There have been so many misunderstandings about the symbolic, about seduction that . . .

SL: The symbolic too?

JB: Oh yes. *Symbolic Exchange* was very well received. Very well indeed. But it was received either by reference to the symbolic in Lacan — sometimes as contrasting with his positions — or within a very religious perspective — as being opposed to rationalism and so on. But the way I tried to get out of all that — in the system of reversibility etc. — wasn't clearly understood. There was an awful lot of confusion, which contributed to the success of the book, but did so on a basis that was somewhat dubious. That has often been the case — as it was with seduction. And when we come to the way simulation has generally been taken up by artists and those in the fine arts, then you have a total misunderstanding. But that takes us away from the subject.

SL: Well, if you'll excuse my obsession, can I perhaps bring you back to the question about Heidegger?

JB: Yes, let's take the question of 'enframing', *das Ge-stell*, and 'The Question Concerning Technology'. For a long time, I found that a problem, because the analysis I made of the system and the code, etc. could be said to amount, ultimately, to a somewhat Heideggerian analysis — technology as the definitive realization of metaphysics, a rather nostalgic vision, in the end, of the 'other' of technology. Whereas now, in fact, I'm much more inclined to drop this Heideggerian vision and find a kind of ironic principle of technology. In other words, to pose the question — to which I don't have an answer — of whether technology (and all the system of virtuality and so on) is really the mode of enslavement of the real, the mode of extermination of the real, and thus the total dis-illusioning of the world, or whether, in the end, technology might not be a detour — a gigantic, but also an ironic, paradoxical detour adopted by the illusion of the world, the radical illusion of the world. So we would be wrong, as it were, about the manifest, official objective of technology and its consequences. Beneath the immense system of technology and all that goes with it, the

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object – or something of that order – would be there playing out its game, playing its own game and perhaps fooling us into thinking we possess a kind of mastery over it. Then the question takes on quite a different complexion. And there we leave the Heideggerian problematic.

SL: Like Heidegger, you also speak in this book of the extermination of the object in hyperreality, but you believe the object would be in play behind . . .

JB: Yes. But this is a difficult question, because there will never be any way of verifying. Verification is practically impossible. So we are left once and for all with the ironic situation of two hypotheses which are incompatible but are perhaps both true. [Laughter.] As Wittgenstein says, the world is everything which is the case. There is a kind of ambiguous self-evidence here – entirely ambiguous.

RB: What are the contemporary forms of reciprocity? Are these to be found in the family, in . . .?

JB: No. I don't see this in psychological or relational terms any longer. Or micro-individual or inter-individual terms. It's my impression that there is reciprocity in what might best be termed the zone of impossible exchanges. There's symbolic exchange. And then there's commodity exchange, on the basis of equivalence, which is not the same thing at all and does not involve reciprocity. So reciprocity is to be found, then, in forms of impossible exchange – exchanges which are impossible for our system.

I've analysed exchanges between terrorists and hostages, the type of relation where there is a terrible reciprocity, where reciprocity takes violent, almost unacceptable forms.

RB: But isn't terrorism beyond reciprocity?

JB: No, I believe that somewhere, in a certain kind of violence like that, one precisely gets beyond the confrontation between subject and object, persecutor and victim. This is what Bataille talked about as well. . . . You get back to this sort of continuity of the cycle of reversibility. You find it in Bataille's concept of continuity too. This sometimes takes material form. As for precise cases, I cannot say. But between terrorists and hostages or persecutors and victims,

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there is a form of exchanging of roles, a role reversal. It was Eric Gans, an American who has made an analysis of that kind, who said: 'We can only grasp the secret of human destiny if we can grasp, in all its horror, this confusion of persecutor and victim. And I think, on this same model, we can only grasp the sense of human mind if we can grasp in all its irony this coincidence of subject and object.'

RB: So there is nothing beyond reciprocity. The difference between Bataille and yourself is that, for you, there is nothing beyond reciprocity?

JB: Yes. It was only afterwards that I began to think about this, but Bataille's general economy is still too economic. Equivalence is transgressed, with 'expenditure' and all that, but the basic concepts are still those of production or overproduction, of the necessity to spend, to find the accursed share. Whereas, in reversibility, everything is 'accursed share' or there is no 'accursed share', since there is no residue. We can take an example from *Symbolic Exchange*, namely the example of the analysis of poetic language, where there is no residue, nothing left over, since everything is exhausted in the reciprocity of terms, in the reversibility of terms – or in Saussure's anagrams. At this point, in this set-up (we can't call it an economy any longer), we are entirely beyond economics and even beyond Bataille's general economy, which is all the same a kind of prodigality, of resolution by prodigality of the problems of political economy. This is more or less how it is. Bataille seems to me quite brilliant by comparison with the way classical political economy poses problems, naturally, but he still seems relatively caught in the trap of economics. I don't say this by any means as a criticism or a rejection. It's not that.

SL: Perhaps we can come back to something you spoke about yesterday[1] and which fascinated many people: your comments on morality. I have a question about morality, but it is also perhaps a question about your pessimism or optimism, though I'm not exactly sure about this. Currently, in Britain, there's a great vogue for Levinas, which has been going on for about a year . . .

JB: We have the same phenomenon in France, though perhaps over the last two years . . .

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SL: And yet he's been around for 50 or 60! . . . What interests me here – I quite like Levinas, but in a sense I'm a bit against him – is that there's a pessimism in Levinas in that, for him, what exists is of the order of the 'There is' but not of the '*Es gibt*'. When I re-read *Symbolic Exchange* a few weeks ago, having read it many years ago in French, there seemed to be some '*Es gibt*' there, since there is either the gift or, alternatively, a generosity, a plenitude, the possibility of a fullness. Whereas, in Levinas, everything is empty and this seems pessimistic. So how are we going to find an ethics, a morality? . . . Yesterday you said we mustn't create a morality based on the subject. This is now the wrong tack . . .

JB: Yes, if I can just interject something here. We didn't have enough time to talk about this yesterday. Effectively, as a subject (and even if we take the theoretical option of analysing the object, we remain subjects), it is impossible – at that subject level – not to have a morality. But, in my view, there's an inevitable dissociation here. Even without bringing in Descartes' double morality, everyone has two levels of this kind. At least we have to speak of another level where morality no longer exists, where things are analysed in a way that goes beyond morality. And not just in Nietzschean terms – which would involve, as with Bataille, the idea of a 'beyond' of, or transgression of values, a transvaluation of values etc. – but, if we are in the space of the object (the space of what there is on the other side), the refraction of that space is not at all the same any more and there the question of morality can't even arise. This is the case with the space of the current news media. There is always a problem about the ethics of news reporting (do we need a media code of ethics etc.?), but it is a false problem since there's no relation between these two things: there's no possibility of a relation between the news media, as they actually function, and the transcendence of a morality. The news and information media function by contiguity, by capillarity, by a kind of total metonymy, but there isn't the slightest possibility in all that of a moral metaphor, a moral transcendence, etc. The two things can't be connected. It's a false problem.

SL: But a morality without transcendence, an ethics without transcendence? An ethics of symbolic exchange surely has nothing to do with transcendence. It's a rooted ethics, an ethics not governed by the law, but by rules – governed by practices, not by laws . . .

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JB: Or one can make a distinction – as I do – between values and forms. I am not speaking of a morality which bears on values, because I don't believe in a morality of that kind any more. But there are also forms. And they are something quite different. Values are perishable; they are dying away. We can at least take the view that there's nothing more to be had from a system of values. But, in my opinion, *forms* are indestructible. By forms, I mean things like seduction, challenges, reversibility. Reversibility, in particular, is a form. And it doesn't give rise in any way to a *moral* principle of action; it's a form, and what we have here is play. Forms are something which we play out – at the level of illusion and 'the rules of the game', etc. And obeying the rules of a game is not a morality, but simply a conforming to the game itself. It's not a matter of saying I accept or reject the rule. I play and, if I play, there is an immanent rule. Not a rule that is defined as something elsewhere, as something transcendent to the game. It *is* the game: the way or play [*jeu*] of the world. And if I am in that game – at the level of appearances etc. – then there is no law or morality in that. But that is not to say that this is immoral in the diabolical, 'bad' sense of the term. Nor even in the Nietzschean sense, perhaps. It is something self-evident: the self-evidence of the rule. There can be behaviours, then, or even a whole culture organized around this form of illusion and reversibility. It will not be moral in the sense we were speaking about. But the difficulty is avoiding the kind of immoral pessimism there may be in not accepting that. It's always being said that I'm pessimistic, nihilistic, etc. But this isn't a nihilism, because there is in it a kind of acceptance – not acceptance in the sense of being resigned to something, but a taking on board – of what is self-evident, of what is the rule. This is neither optimism nor pessimism. It's the game. And the pleasure of the game. It is not at all nihilistic.

RB: Are we talking of a local or a universal game?

JB: It can be all kinds of local games – very fragmented, very fractal, very intermittent. It can also be conceived – though it must be stressed that it isn't a metaphysics – as *le jeu du monde*: the 'play' of the world . . .

SL: To come back to the earlier question. The morality you speak of, the subjectless morality – well, not entirely subjectless, but not subject-based – which is in rules, in games, is a little

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Wittgensteinian. This puts me in mind of the neo-Aristotelians – people like Charles Taylor and MacIntyre . . .

JB: Or gaming and the *differend*. There's Lyotard too.

SL: Even Foucault at the end.

JB: Yes.

SL: When I read your descriptions of symbolic exchange, I think of classical, medieval society and read them, for example, as casting light on that. But in our present society things are not so fixed and distinct. Where are we to find the possibility of these exchanges? They must be somewhere, but where?

JB: Ultimately, what might be closest to a morality would be a rule of stripping-away [*dépouillement*], the rule of the Stoics. This isn't something positive, so that you'd say: 'There's a value here, you have to behave according to that value'. There is no ideality here, but an indifference on the part of the world and nature. And the only virtue, at bottom, is in not adding *pathos* to the world. In other words, in not adding to desire the *pathos* of desire, not adding to suffering the *pathos* of suffering, etc. That is what the subject does with value: his transcendence is a kind of adding-weight-to – an increasing – of the world's indifference. The only task, then, would be to clear a space, as it were, around the object, to act so that it shone out resplendent in all its indifference, in its immorality, though not in a negative sense – perhaps amorality would be better – so that the subject himself can attune himself to the world, harmonize with the world in a kind of symbolic exchange of indifference.

Indifference circulates because indifference isn't nothing; it isn't negative. It is, perhaps, a passion. At all events, that's what it could be said to be for me. Perhaps even the fundamental passion. And so far as that passion is concerned – a passion being a dual relation, a circulation of things – perhaps the closest ethical world could be said to be that of Stoicism. But that isn't really a historical reference for me; Stoicism isn't the origin of my position, nor is it what I come back to, but there is an affinity.

It's true, however, that this question of morality or immorality is often reduced to a value judgement, which consists in saying: you

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are pessimistic, you are nihilistic and so on. It's often resolved in terms of optimism or pessimism. The whole of morality ultimately consists in believing that it is possible to be moral. Morality is founded wholly and solely on this moralistic *petitio principii*. And you're not forgiven for questioning this. I've not been forgiven for this: for not according value, for not adding value to something, to some particular process and, ultimately, for offering no kind of solution, opening or ideal, or the like. In that sense, I am indifferent. Not nihilistic but indifferent. And I believe there is philosophy only after you have succeeded in setting aside this kind of presupposition of value. But that is unpardonable, unacceptable . . .

RB: At what level are we to understand this concept of indifference?

JB: Well, though I've given the example of Stoicism, I'm not talking about that kind of philosophical indifference, but about indifference in relation to our current *pathos*, our current system. And our system is a system of non-differentiation [*indifférentiation*] too. It too — the system of coding and decoding of information, of virtuality — puts an end to this kind of dialectic of terms. It is beyond that. Simulation is nothing less than the abolition of the opposition between true and false, good and evil, etc. So, simulation is obviously not the false; it is the neither-true-nor-false. The whole system is a kind of realization of indifference, almost a form of indifference incarnate.

Now, obviously, it's not the indifference of seduction or of symbolic exchange; it's something short of that. In a way we might be said to have realized Nietzsche's transvaluation of values, but to have realized it not 'beyond good and evil', but, sadly, 'this side of good and evil'. We have to come to terms with this situation. However, the rule must be not to try to escape this kind of profound indifference of the system by retrieving value and difference, but to try to play with this indifference — this objective indifference which is our destiny — to manage to transform this fateful indifference into the rule of the game, if not indeed play with it. And to recover a sort of passion for indifference. Isn't the new register, the new space of a new form of game to be found in indifference itself, which is in theory the opposite of all passion?

Now, gaming is a passion. If we rediscover either the cards or the rules of the game, we rediscover the possibility of playing or gaming. The problem — and it is a paradox — is that, as you might say, we

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have the cards – a certain number of cards to play with – but we don't have the rules. That, in fact, is more or less how I see it. And what do I do? I deal out a few cards, but I can't provide the rules. I don't know them myself. Or, alternatively, you might say that we have the rules, but we don't have the cards. That's true of thought, perhaps. At a particular point, you can find a kind of . . . not the key to the mystery, but the space of the mystery. But we don't have the cards, because all the cards have been stolen by the system. It's the system that holds all the cards. So we never have both the cards and the rules at the same time, if I can put it this way. This is a situation which is, for the moment – and doubtless irreversibly – irresolvable. And this situation of irresolvability is tragic, if you like, but not dramatic. It isn't pessmistic. It isn't nihilistic. Quite the opposite. It is *the* situation and, in that sense, it is an original one.

So we shouldn't attack the system negatively any more or critically take it to task for not giving us the cards to play with, because that seems to me entirely nostalgic and pessimistic – nihilistic: the essence of nihilism. We have to transform it. It's a bit like Borges's 'Lottery in Babylon', where chance, randomness, which is the very opposite of freedom, transmutes itself into the rules of the game – i.e. we have to find the possibility of playing in the very impossibility of being ourselves. In my view; this kind of operation isn't exceptional; it isn't the preserve of theorists: you can try and do it in thought, but in my opinion people in their lives do it every day. It's the game of life.

When I said yesterday we are all terminals, that was a logical description of the system itself; but I believe and hope – otherwise I wouldn't even speak – that philosophy and art have no special privileges here. In terms of neurons – intelligence and knowledge, etc. – there's a profound inequality, of course, but where symbolic exchange, reversibility and the rest are concerned, everyone has the same potential. Everyone is equal before the rule. We are not equal before the law, of course: the law is a principle of profound inequality. But everyone is equal before the rule because it is arbitrary. So there we find the foundations of a true democracy, if I may put it like that, though not by any means of the usual political type.

SL: I've a lot of sympathy for your position, but I'm not sure I understand these 'terms'? . . .

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JB: There's a possible confusion. It's true that today everything circulates. But there are no longer any terms, there is no longer *the* terminal, *the* network. What we have is the circulation of the network and the circuit, if I may put it like that. We're no longer in the realm of that kind of indefinite metaphor which, for example, means that in the symbolic exchange between human beings there's a form of symbolic transfusion of forms between them — animals, men, nature, etc. — that whole cycle which went round and round, where forms were transformed into each other.

Today, what we have is pure circulation, which is that of the pure network, where there are no longer even any forms. The circulation of the network is the circulation of formulas, if I can put it that way. It's playing on words a bit, but what we have here is no longer a form, but a formula — the highly simplified coding of information, etc.

And, where this circulation is concerned, there's no possibility, for example, of stopping. That's the problem: we have lost even the secret of stopping things, of halting them. But symbolic exchange always implies the possibility of death, of stopping, falling still, being suspended. With symbolic exchange, there's a whole dramaturgy. On the other hand, with the network and circulation on the network, there's no dramaturgy. It's not metaphor any more, but metabolism. This is very different, and yet it's true that in neither case are there any longer any terms.

There are, if you like, three possibilities. There is a possibility of a reign of symbolic exchange, in which there is continuity, a cycle and so on; then, there is an intermediary form, as one might put it, which we might call that of terms and the opposition of terms, of meaning, rationality, etc.; then, beyond that, in virtuality, we are once again in a register where there are no terms or poles, where everything is in a form of indeterminacy, but that indeterminacy is not symbolic at all. This is not irreversibility, it is indeterminacy. And there — and this is complicated, since we have to look at some of the most contemporary theories of indeterminacy (chaos theory, etc.) — there are many similarities with reversibility and the like, but what we find is not reversibility, but turbulence and indeterminacy. This is all very exciting, but it's a long way from the world of the Enlightenment and reason, from the conventional world of rationality: we are in the fractal, the molecular, the plural, the random, the chaotic. There's a whole world there, but there are no

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'rules of the game' in that world. It is in a state of disorder, whereas symbolic exchange is an order. There are rules to it. Though it's true that there may be many resemblances between the two, they should not be conflated.

Otherwise, we come back to the ahistorical, timeless hypothesis that we are always dealing with the same situations, the same forms: things never change; the terms of the exchange are filtered through different technologies, but they are always the same and no radical change has occurred at all. That may perhaps be satisfying for the mind – in the sense of celebrating a timeless spirit – but what's the point of talking about it in that case? We have to start out from the fact that something has happened – a break, a mutation has taken place – and that we are in a new world.

Here I'll defend the idea of 'difference', because we have to cultivate difference a little here, mark the difference. Otherwise, thought is pointless. Thought is, after all, a discourse – *discursus* – and, necessarily, there is difference: at a particular point something happens and things are not the same afterwards. Here, I think, there is a genuine break after modernity. This is perhaps the only case in which we can really take the term 'postmodern' seriously. There has been a kind of break, and I think even the philosophy of the philosophers – and I include Foucault and Derrida in this – doesn't take this mutation (which is very subtle) into account in all its consequences.

And I mean by this that we are now in a different world. This is not science fiction, but I know it perhaps takes a kind of anticipation to sense what this other thing is. We have really passed beyond something, perhaps even beyond the end – I've analysed this question in *The Illusion of the End* – and, in fact, there is no finality or end any longer, because we have already passed beyond. And there, the rules are no longer the same.

SL: But in *Symbolic Exchange*, there are already no finalities. . . . For us, in the Anglo-Saxon world, this is perhaps a little difficult to understand, perhaps because we are not clear about what you mean by 'terms' and 'finalities'.

JB: 'Term' is the word for the 'end' in all its ambiguity, because in French, too, the 'term' is the end and the finality, i.e. the ideal end of something, which is a bit different. But you can play on the two. Now, in *Symbolic Exchange*, there was effectively no finality, but reversibility. And what is reversible isn't final.

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SL: The world is not final either . . .

JB: No, it is a form of reversibility. Extermination certainly is final – extermination which I was speaking of yesterday and which I take literally as ex-termination. *Ex-terminus*: what has passed beyond the end, so to speak.

Now, in the system of reason and modernity, progress, etc., there is an end, a transcendence, etc. and we are now beyond that, in a kind of other system which has passed beyond the end. We are not this-side-of finality, but already beyond finality. This is what I mean when I say everything is realized. We are in the absolute real, so to speak. The virtual is the same thing. And having to make sense of a world where the end is not ahead of us but behind us and already realized, changes everything. The whole nature of the problem has changed. This is a hypothesis which seems to me to cast a certain amount of light on all the current impasses of philosophy – the impossibility of rethinking the problem of values, of freedom or utopia, etc. In France, everyone is trying to find a new basis for political thought, re-reading Kant and so on. That seems to me to smack rather of despair.

Translated by Chris Turner

Notes

1. A reference to Baudrillard's talk at the ICA 'The Virtual Illusion or the Automatic Writing of the World', December 1994, published elsewhere in this issue.

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